

E-mail #3: "Approaching a Prospect"

In my last e-mail we discussed converting a suspect to a prospect by checking to make sure he or she was not already an advertiser, and by developing a prospect card. Please review the protected advertisers list before proceeding.

If everything has gone well, you should have a stack of 20 to 30 qualified names. You may now be wondering how to contact them and what you are going to say. As always, a few minutes of preparation in advance can be enormously beneficial.

Step 1: Decide the best method to contact the prospect: If you know the prospect through business and are comfortable talking with them on the phone, then a phone call is appropriate. However, if you are a customer who only knows the prospect because of your face to face encounters, then you might want to plan on visiting with him/her in person.

Step 2: Prepare for your Conversation: A good sales presentation begins by engaging the prospect in a conversation by asking questions.... however, you should only ask questions which will result in answers that support your cause. So here is a sample "sales conversation" starter that you might consider using:

INTRODUCTION: "Mr Prospect, do you have a few minutes that we might talk? I am very excited about my association with HLSR."

QUESTION: "Have you ever considered being involved with the Houston Livestock Show and Rodeo?" This is a good opening question because it gives you a starting point for your discussion. The following are the possible answers:

POTENTIAL ANSWER 1: "Yes, I am on the ____ committee and have been for years." He/She may talk about his experience at length and with enthusiasm. If so, you should let them talk, and you share their enthusiasm before continuing with your response.

RESPONSE: "Great, as you know it is a wonderful charity with a great cause and has an enormous impact on the Houston economy. Have you ever considered advertising in the Souvenir Program?" The prospect's potential answers here might be yes, no or a request for more information such as "what do you mean?" or "what is it?" Whatever his/her response, you should acknowledge it and then proceed to your "Presentation" which will be covered in the next e-mail.

POTENTIAL ANSWER 2: "Yes, I buy a (pig, chicken, barbecue tent, etc.) each year from my (brother, friend, business associate, etc.)." Once again let them tell their story while you listen intently.

RESPONSE: "Great, did you know there are additional ways to support HLSR that may actually serve not on only your philanthropic desires, but might also help your business?" Whatever his/her response, acknowledge it and proceed to your "Presentation" which will be covered in the next e-mail.

POTENTIAL ANSWER 3: "No, I haven't considered getting involved because" The potential responses here range from "I am too busy" to "I didn't know anything about it".

RESPONSE: "There are many ways to be involved ranging from the very active involvement of joining a committee to the more passive and potentially lucrative method of simply advertising in the Houston Livestock Show and Rodeo Souvenir Program, which is the committee I represent. May I tell you more about my committee and the Souvenir Program?" Whatever his/her response, acknowledge it and proceed to your "Presentation" which will be covered in the next e-mail.

That's it.... You have now engaged the prospect and prepared him for your presentation! My next e-mail will cover the potential presentation that you might use in a form that fits your style.

One last thing... please let us know what you are using that is working. The strategies I am sharing in these e-mails are time tested sales strategies, but they are not the only strategies. The meetings are our chance to share our successes so we can help every member badge!!